SOP-COM-002 · Apple account recovery: for the people who hold your keys

SOP COM-002 | Status draft | Changed 2026-11-05 | For Account holders and their contacts

Department: COM · **ID:** 002 · **Status:** draft (approved when tagged) · **Owner:** the lab (Chris W, the steward) · **Last changed:** 2026-11-05

> ***Note.*** *This page is for two readers at once: the **account holder** who turned on Apple's strongest protection, and the **people they chose** to hold a way back in. It names roles, never people. The holder keeps their own private list of who is who. Written from Apple's own support pages, read on 2026-11-04 and linked below; Apple changes these things, so check the links when it matters.*

Purpose

When an Apple account is protected end to end, Apple can no longer open it for you. A person who loses their password and every device needs one of three things: a trusted device, a **recovery contact**, or a **recovery key**. After a death, a **legacy contact** needs an access key. This page says what each role is, what each person can and cannot do, and how to practise before it is needed.

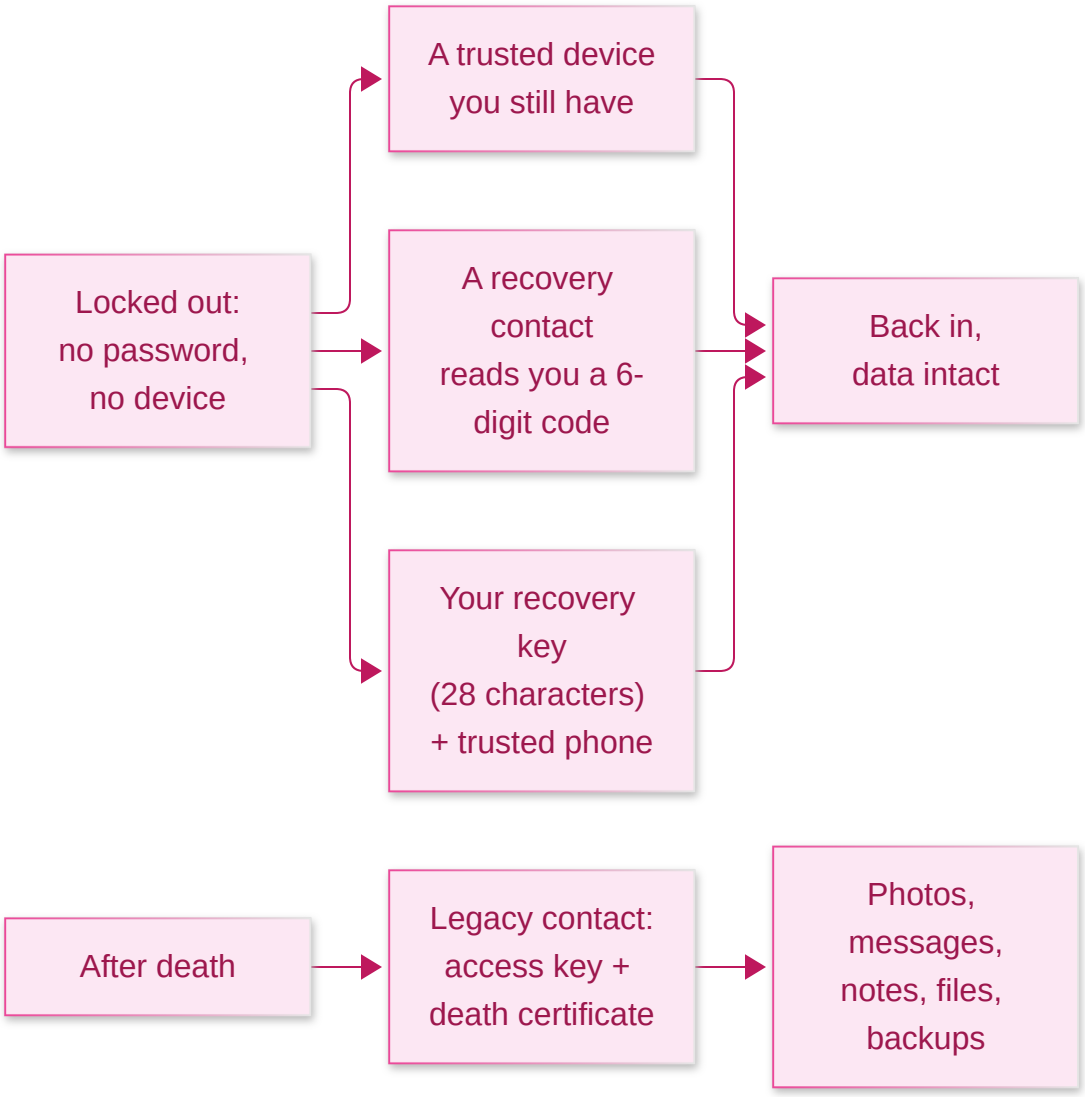
Scope

Any member or steward who turns on **Advanced Data Protection** for iCloud, and anyone they name as a recovery or legacy contact. It covers the Apple account only. Passwords for GitHub, banks or wallets have their own pages; a password manager's emergency kit is mentioned because the two now depend on each other.

Roles

Role	Does	Can see	Cannot
Account holder	turns the protection on, names contacts, keeps the key, tests yearly	everything	ask Apple to open the account once the key is set
Recovery contact (up to five)	when asked, reads a **six-digit code** from their own Apple device to the holder, by phone or in person	the code, nothing else	see photos, messages, files, or sign in; Apple does not even know their name
Recovery key	a 28-character code the holder keeps on paper or in a password manager		be recovered from Apple if lost: a lost key and lost devices mean a lost account
Legacy contact	after the holder's death, requests the data with the **access key** and a death certificate	photos, messages, notes, files, backups	purchases, subscriptions, saved passwords, passkeys, payment cards

The three ways back in



Prerequisites

- Two-factor sign-in on the Apple account (Apple requires it for the protection to turn on).
- Every device on the account updated (iOS 16.2, macOS 13.1 or later for the protection; recovery contacts need iOS 15 / macOS 12 or later and iMessage on).
- At least one recovery contact **or** a recovery key before the protection turns on; both is the lean.
- A paper copy of the recovery key and of your password manager's emergency kit, away from your devices. Apple cannot replace a lost key.

Steps

1 · For the account holder: set it up (about 20 minutes)

1. System Settings → your name → **Sign-In & Security** → **Recovery Contacts** → Add. Choose people who will answer the phone in a bad week. Each one must **accept in Messages**; until then they do not count. Apple tells you when one accepts ("you'll see a message that they've been added") and notifies you if one declines or later removes themselves. Silence is not a yes: ask each person to confirm, and do it again at the yearly test. *You should see:* their names listed with "accepted".
2. Same screen → **Recovery Key** → Turn On. Write the 28 characters down **by hand** and keep that paper as the real copy (see *The day every device is gone*); a password manager is a convenient second copy, not the only one. Apple's own warning: never in Apple Passwords, Notes, Photos or iCloud Drive, because those are what is locked when you need it. *You should see:* "Recovery Key: On".

3. Same screen → **Legacy Contact** → Add. Apple makes an **access key**; send it by iMessage (it is stored on their device when they accept) or print it. *You should see:* each name listed.
4. Your name → **iCloud** → **Advanced Data Protection** → Turn On. *You should see:* "On". From now on Apple does not hold the keys to your iCloud Drive, Photos, Notes, backups or Messages backups.
5. Write a private page that lists who holds which role and where the key lives (the lab's helpers keep theirs in a private spec). This public page never names anyone.

2 · For a recovery contact: what to do when the call comes

1. The holder phones you or stands in front of you and says they are locked out. **Ask them something only they would know.** A stranger with their phone number is the risk this role exists to stop.
2. Open Settings → your name → **Sign-In & Security**, find the recovery section (Apple renames it between versions: *Recovery Contacts* or *Account Recovery*), tap their name → **Get Recovery Code**. *You should see:* six digits.
3. Read the six digits to them, by voice. Never text them to a number you did not already have, never read them to anyone else, never to an email.
4. That is all. You never see their data; the code only lets them set a new password.

3 · For a legacy contact: what to do one day

1. Find the access key (the iMessage thread where it was sent, or the paper).
2. Go to Apple's Digital Legacy page, enter the access key, and upload the death certificate. Apple reviews it and then gives you a special Apple account to download the data.
3. Decide with the family what to keep. Apple notes each legacy contact can act alone, including deleting; talk first.

4 · The yearly test (15 minutes, put it on the calendar)

1. Holder: the Sign-In & Security screen still lists the contacts as accepted, the key as On, the legacy contacts as set.
2. Each recovery contact: on their own device, under Sign-In & Security, your name is listed and they can find **Get Recovery Code**. This is the only way to know for sure that the person will be there. Ten minutes on a call, once a year.
3. Both paper copies still exist and are readable, and the key on them still reads 28 characters. Check the seal on the one held elsewhere.
4. Each legacy contact can still find their access key.
5. Note the date on the holder's private page.

The day every device is gone

The test for all of this is a house fire: every Mac and phone gone at once. Walk it through before it happens.

You will need	Where it must be, so a fire cannot take it
A new Apple device	a store. Apple's recovery runs on an Apple device
Your trusted phone number	your carrier can reissue it to a new SIM. Know the account's PIN, and write it on the paper below
The recovery key, on paper	Apple's own advice is "a printed or handwritten copy" in a safe place, because a lost key cannot be replaced
Your password manager's emergency kit, on paper, with its master password kept in your head or sealed beside it	anywhere but a device or a cloud drive that needs this same account to open
A recovery contact who answers	their phone, not yours, which is why a contact is the second way in

A loop is the thing to look for. A key inside a password manager, whose kit sits on a drive that needs the Apple account to open, is one chain: lose the devices and every link goes at once. An encrypted image on iCloud is a good backup and a bad last resort, for this reason.

Two paper copies, two places. One in a fire-resistant safe at home. A home safe alone still fails a flood or a theft, so the second goes away from the house: a bank box, or a sealed envelope with someone you trust who is not one of your recovery contacts. A sealed copy held by someone else is only as private as the seal, so date it and check the seal at the yearly test.

What never happens here

- Nobody is ever asked for a password, a code or the key by text, email or a stranger on the phone. A real recovery is a voice you know.
- The recovery key is never typed into a website, a chat or an AI helper.
- This page never names the contacts. The holder's private list does.

Sources (read 2026-11-04)

- Apple, *iCloud data security overview*: https://support.apple.com/en-us/102651
- Apple, *Set up a recovery contact for your Apple Account*: https://support.apple.com/en-us/102641
- Apple, *Set up a recovery key for your Apple Account*: https://support.apple.com/en-us/109345
- Apple, *How to add a Legacy Contact for your Apple Account*: https://support.apple.com/en-us/102631

Not legal advice. A will and an estate plan say who may act after a death; a legacy contact is Apple's door, not the law's.

Part of the fleet's procedures. The master copies and the legend live in my-template.